



ANTONYMS

Words that mean the opposite of each other

1 What is it?

Antonyms (AN-tuh-nimz)

An antonym is a word that means the opposite of another word. Antonyms help writers create contrast and highlight differences clearly.

a word + its exact opposite

2 See it in action

Hot/Cold

"The soup was **hot**; the drink was **cold**."

Light/Dark

"The room was **light** at noon, **dark** by evening."

Fast/Slow

"He ran **fast**; the tortoise moved **slow**."

Brave/Cowardly

"She was **brave**, while he was **cowardly**."



Keep going!

Try building an antonym pair for five adjectives in your last piece of writing — it's a quick way to check your vocabulary range.

3 More to know

Full/Empty

"The tank was **full** this morning, but **empty** by evening."

Kind/Cruel

"His **kind** words replaced her **cruel** ones."

FUN FACT

The prefixes "un-", "in-", "im-", "dis-" and "non-" can all create an antonym in English, which is why "happy" becomes "unhappy" but "possible" becomes "impossible" rather than "unpossible".

4 Why it's used

Antonyms help: create clear contrast, tension and balance in writing — putting opposite ideas side by side often makes each one feel more powerful.

Some antonyms are formed by adding a prefix to the original word (happy → unhappy, possible → impossible), while others are completely different words (hot → cold).



You got this!

Remember some words have more than one opposite depending on context — always check which meaning of the word you're working with.

5 Don't mix it up

ANTONYMS

Antonyms are words with opposite meanings — "hot" and "cold".

SYNONYMS

Synonyms are different words with similar meanings — "hot" and "warm".

⚠ Watch out!

Some words have more than one antonym depending on context — the opposite of "hard" could be "soft" (texture) or "easy" (difficulty), so check the meaning being used.

6 Quick recap

Opposite meaning

Creates contrast

Sometimes formed with a prefix



Think about...

Putting an antonym pair close together in a sentence (hot and cold, light and dark) is a simple, effective way to create contrast.